

This summer, I, like many others, spent a considerable time watching the Beijing Olympics. The Olympic ideal is born of pure sportsmanship, individuals competing at the highest level for the sheer glory of taking home a gold medal from the world's ultimate sporting event. Who can forget the extraordinary achievements of the American swimmer Michael Phelps winning an unprecedented nine gold medals?

I'm sure that, like Phelps, many of those competing in Beijing had done little else but train for the past four years, if not longer. And that not just competing, but winning, was the main spur behind many of these performances. But the Olympics is not just about gold medals. Behind the sporting events, there is also a strong national element. The opening and closing ceremonies, the flag-bearing processions, the scrutiny over which nation leads the medals table, and the presence of political leaders in the crowd, all reflect this.

It was clear that China had invested an

enormous amount, not just in money but in training and dedication by thousands of athletes and coaches over many years. In addition to achieving winning results, the Games had to be an organisational success—a symbol, if you like, of the country's amazing recent economic progress. Unsurprisingly, China delivered on both fronts. It pushed the mighty Americans off the number one spot for gold medals. And it amazed viewers worldwide with the majesty, quality and efficiency of the event itself. In doing so, it substantially increased the country's standing in the world. And I imagine it made every member of the nation a little prouder to be Chinese.

I wonder how many people in India were just a little bit envious of the show China had put on and their gold medal-winning performances? Is it realistic to expect India to deliver a similar result? Are we likely to achieve the same results in the forthcoming Commonwealth Games? India and China are often coupled together as the two powerhouses of economic growth. But when it comes to Olympic glory, India is nowhere to be seen.

Signed, Sealed and Delivered

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